A-League Player Sales: 2019/20 to the 2026/27 mid-year window

Dataset and method | Identifying departures that returned money

Overview

This document details how a sample of A-League sales was assembled, and why each departure in it qualifies. The method section defines what counted as money returned to a selling club, and how competing sources were ranked where they disagreed. The season records then work through each transfer cycle, detailing the reasoning behind each departure's inclusion, and the near misses with the reasoning for their exclusion.

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Method

Scope

This document records how a dataset of A-League Men player sales was assembled, in an effort to analyse recent trends in the market for A-League players. A departure qualified for inclusion when it satisfied two criteria:

1. *It returned money to the selling club.* A registered player transferred from an A-League club to another club that returned money to the selling club. Money returns to an A-League club on a player sale in four forms- a transfer fee, a training-compensation entitlement under FIFA regulation, a payment triggering a release clause, or a loan fee (Fédération Internationale de Football Association [FIFA], 2025). Any one of these forms qualified a departure for inclusion.
2. *It occurred within the sample period.* The period runs from the 2019/20 season to the 2026/27 mid-year window. Four structural changes affect comparability within it: Western United entered the competition in 2019/20 (Western United FC, n.d.), Macarthur FC in 2020/21 (A-Leagues, 2020), Auckland in 2024/25 (Auckland FC, 2024), and Western United did not field a team in 2025/26 (Australian Professional Leagues, 2025), before being removed from the league permanently in August 2026 (Australian Broadcasting Corporation, 2026). The number of clubs generating departures is therefore not constant across the cycles in the sample.

The competition-level census returned 1,264 departures across the sample period (Transfermarkt, n.d.), of which 128 were included. The inclusion figure is not an objective reflection of how many A-League player sales occurred. Rather, it represents the number of departures for which the available evidence supports reasonable confidence that the selling club recouped money. This will likely understate the true number, given the limited public reporting.

Why the sample begins in 2019/20

The cut-off is supported by a noticeable shift in the export market rather than a convenient point. Before 2019 the Chinese Super League was a key destination for Australian players, fielding twelve in 2016 with two more in the second tier, a contingent exceeded only by Brazil, and falling to none by 2018 (Hassett, 2018). A transfer levy from June 2017 doubled the cost of a foreign signing for a loss-making club (Porteous, n.d.), salary caps followed in December 2019 (Xinhua, 2019), and more than twenty clubs were removed from the Chinese professional leagues inside two years (Agence France-Presse, 2021). No departure in this dataset returned money from a Chinese club. Pooling the two periods would combine two distinct markets, one in which the league's saleable assets were late-career veterans bound for Asia, and one in which they are players in their early twenties bound for Europe or North

America. Restricting the sample to a later window would reduce the number of departures significantly. Further, a narrower window can always be isolated from a longer one.

The start point is practical as well as analytical. This dataset rests on what clubs said at the time, and club digital archives become consistently retrievable from around 2019. A method built on club announcements depends on those announcements surviving, so extending the period backwards would add seasons in which more departures sit unresolved rather than extend the evidence.

A sensitivity check further supports the cut-off. Tightening the cut-off to 2023/24 moves the mean age at transfer by 0.1 years (22.5 to 22.4) and the European and North American share of destinations by three percentage points (76.6% to 79.5%), while discarding 50 of the 128 included departures (39%).

Sourcing for Classification

No register of A-League transfer income exists. Clubs are under no obligation to disclose whether a fee was involved, most do not name amounts, and commercial transfer databases can be unreliable on this point. In particular, departures that other sources establish as having returned money appear in Transfermarkt and comparable services labelled as free transfers (see Season Records). Because this describes most A-League sales, the resulting error systematically understates the number of departures that can be identified as returning money. No label from a database was therefore treated as definitive evidence of a transfer's categorisation.

Per-club season records list departures against a set of labels- a stated amount, undisclosed, free transfer, end of contract, mutual contract termination. However, these labels are compiled by third parties, rather than by a party to the transaction. They record what was published about a departure rather than what was agreed. They were therefore used to surface candidates for checking, not to settle how a departure was classified.

Greatest weight was given to the announcements made by the selling and buying clubs. The two clubs are party to the transaction, and the wording of their statements is a usable instrument for classifying it. A club stating that a player left "for an undisclosed fee" is asserting that a fee was paid without naming it (Adelaide United, 2021), whereas a club stating that a player "has decided to leave the Club to explore an opportunity overseas" appears to be describing a departure it is not claiming to have been paid for (Adelaide United, 2019). Because each club's account is open to contradiction by the other, these statements are the closest available record of what took place. Where sources conflict, the clubs' announcements prevailed as the most reliable source of transfer categorisation.

What Qualified as Money Received

A departure entered the sample if it satisfied one of three conditions: (a) an amount is published for the transfer (a published amount is treated as evidence that a fee was paid, not as a reliable measure of its size); (b) a club or contemporary press source states that a fee was paid, without necessarily naming it; or, (c) a training-compensation entitlement arises and survives the tests in the next section (see Regulatory Tests). Training compensation is a regulatory entitlement owed to clubs that trained a player, arising on an international transfer irrespective of contract status (FIFA, 2025). Further, where a sell-on or add-on is known, it is recorded alongside the original transfer, and the distinction between initial fee and realised return is stated.

An additional situation occurs enough to require addressing. A mid-contract transfer is one where a selling club announces a transfer of an under-contract player, without stating whether a transfer fee was involved. A contracted player does not typically move without consideration, but no source states a payment. These are included and graded accordingly (see Evidence Grading), but not treated as equivalent to a club confirmed sale.

Five per cent of any compensation paid on an international transfer is distributed among the clubs that trained the player (FIFA, 2025), and an entitlement can be modelled for nearly every departure in the census. Since the establishment of the FIFA Clearing House in 2022, these contributions have been distributed automatically, rather than claimed by clubs (FIFA, 2024b), yet allocations are not published. Solidarity is therefore paid without being observable. Including modelled solidarity would populate the sample with money that cannot be demonstrated for any particular departure. Therefore, considerations were reserved for a separate study.

Currency and Conversion

Amounts are recorded in euros, because the competition record and most international reporting use them, and reported in Australian dollars. Conversion runs deal by deal at the European Central Bank annual average rate for the year of the transfer, rather than at one rate for the whole period.

Where a club or a report stated a figure in another currency, that figure is the source and the euro value is derived from it on the same annual average basis. The 2026 rate is a year-to-date average of the complete months from January to September, because the year is not finished.

A separate set of columns restates each figure in 2026 euros using the euro-area harmonised index of consumer prices. Nominal and inflation-adjusted figures are reported separately,

because the two answer different questions. What a club received at the time is not what that sum is worth now.

Regulatory Tests

Training compensation is the only mechanism in the dataset governed by a written rule rather than by negotiation, which makes it the most checkable source during compilation. Compensation is payable on an international transfer up to the end of the season of a player's 23rd birthday, but is calculated only on training provided between the ages of 12 and 21 (FIFA, 2025). Both limbs must hold. Age at departure alone is necessary but not sufficient.

Crucially, FIFA states the end of the entitlement two different ways. Its regulations say the end of the season in which a player turns 23 (FIFA, 2025), whereas its guidance for member associations says the end of the calendar year (FIFA, n.d.). Because the A-League season runs across calendar years, the two do not always coincide, and the same departure can fall inside the window on one reading and outside it on the other. Where a conflicting case occurred, there was no basis for preferring one reading over the other, and the departure was excluded rather than admitted on whichever reading favoured inclusion.

Indicative annual rates (UEFA figures) run from roughly €90,000 for a Category I club down through €60,000 and €30,000, whilst a transfer to a Category IV club attracts no compensation at all (FIFA, 2024a). Each confederation sets its own rates, and those outside UEFA are materially lower.

Compensation is not owed where the former club terminates the contract unilaterally without just cause (FIFA, 2025). Yet it survives both contract expiry and mutual termination. It also requires the player to be registered as a professional with the receiving club (FIFA, 2025). Further, compensation arises only on an international transfer. A move from an A-League club to an Australian state-league club produces no entitlement.

Evidence Grading

Deal type and strength of evidence are separate dimensions and are recorded as separate fields. Deal type takes one of four values: (1) transfer fee; (2) release clause; (3) training compensation; or (4) loan fee. Evidence grade for fee entries takes one of six, descending in order of strength: (1) figure reported; (2) band reported, where a club characterises the sum without naming it; (3) club-stated undisclosed (club-stated), where a club confirms a fee but not its size; (4) press-reported, where only a third-party report of a fee exists; (5) inferred from contract status (inferred), where a contracted player moved by club agreement but no source states money; and (6) season-record only. A separate grade, regulatory entitlement, applies to compensation entries, where the warrant is the registration record tested above rather than any report of a fee. A season record alone does not support inclusion. One

included entry carries that grade, Denis Genreau, where inclusion rests on a club statement implying a sale and only the figure comes from the record. That entry is flagged. Every other grade is sufficient for inclusion, whilst the two weakest (press-reported and inferred from contract status) are recorded so that a reader can identify them.

Flagged Entries

Evidence grading records how precisely a sum is known. It does not record how secure an entry's qualification for the sample is. As noted in the Scope section, a departure is included where the available evidence supports reasonable confidence that the selling club recouped money. This standard admits a range. An entry can clear it and still rest on an assumption that could reasonably be wrong. Those entries are flagged.

Three rules determine whether an entry is flagged, and any one of them is sufficient. The first applies to fee entries, whilst the second and third apply to compensation entries, where money arises by regulation, and the absence of a statement therefore proves nothing.

1. An entry is flagged unless a club, the league, or a news report indicates that money was paid, either explicitly or in wording that can only sensibly mean a fee. A selling club's statement that terms were agreed for a player's transfer does not meet this test, since a transfer can be agreed without a transfer fee. Nor does a fee asserted only by an opinion or analysis outlet, which is not authoritative enough to qualify an entry.
2. An entry is flagged where the selling club holds twelve months or less of qualifying training service. FIFA calculates compensation in whole training years (FIFA, 2025), so a club below one year holds less than a single unit of the regulation's own currency.
3. An entry is flagged where the receiving club could reasonably be Category IV, in which case no compensation would be paid (FIFA, 2025). It is not a flag for an unpublished category as such. Where the worst realistic case is Category III, the entitlement survives at a lower rate, which is a question of amount rather than of inclusion. Because few associations' categorisations are publicly published (FIFA, n.d.), the test is applied to the receiving club's standing. A second-tier club, or a club in an association whose clubs are unlikely to be classified above Category IV, attracts the flag.

Twenty-two of the 128 included entries are flagged. Nine fail the first rule, six the second and eight the third, with one entry failing both the second and the third. The flagged entries are, with few exceptions, among the smallest in the sample, so removing them affects the count of departures that returned money far more than the cumulative sum returned. Flagged entries are marked with an asterisk against the entry number in each season's table, with the reason given beneath it.

Limitations

Firstly, qualifying academy departures are likely missing from the final dataset. Academy departures are largely absent from the competition census, and several confirmed sales of academy players surfaced only through club announcements (see Season Records). Evidence is thinnest in the earlier seasons of the dataset, and where such transfers are recorded, the details are often wrong. Therefore, the 128 sample is a floor, rather than a true representation of the qualifying population.

Secondly, category assignments for individual clubs are not published (FIFA, n.d.). Therefore, for several entries, the entitlement's support rests on the inference that a professional club in a national first or second tier is not in the Category IV (or equivalent) band, and its size is not calculable from public sources.

Thirdly, compensation amounts are almost never stated. Almost every compensation entry is an entitlement inferred from the regulations, rather than an observed payment.

Fourthly, the recorded amounts are mostly estimates. Clubs confirm that a fee was paid but rarely name it, so the amount usually comes from a third party rather than from a party to the transaction. These figures are therefore useful for gauging the scale of a deal rather than as an exact record of what was paid.

Fifthly, the dataset records initial transfers rather than realised return. Sell-on percentages and add-ons pay out after the transfer occurs, so a club's total return on a player can exceed the recorded figure by a wide margin.

Finally, the census is not a fixed record. Transfermarkt amends its entries continuously, so the same records can return a different count at a later date. The census figures therefore reflect the retrieval date recorded in Reproducibility (Transfermarkt, n.d.).

Reproducibility

Each potential inclusion was worked in the same sequence. First, the competition-level census was compiled from Transfermarkt's A-League Men transfer pages, one for each season of the sample period (Transfermarkt, n.d.). Second, the per-club season record for each club was read, and the fee column was used to identify candidates the census had labelled ambiguously. These records are third-party compilations, and were used to surface potential candidates only. Third, every candidate was checked against the selling club's own news archive, then against the buying club's, then against contemporary press reporting.

Compensation cases required two further checks that fee cases did not: (1) the player's registration span at the selling club, to establish qualifying training years; and (2) the receiving club's competitive tier, to establish whether Category IV could be excluded. Where a judgement remains unresolved, it is marked as such rather than resolved in either direction.

All sources were retrieved between 5 and 20 September 2026.

Season Records

Each season below gives the departures included in the sample, the two labels for each, and the reasoning for any entry that is not self-evident from the table. Departures that were close to qualifying, yet were not included, were also discussed.

2019/20

The competition census for the cycle comprised 149 departure rows, of which ten are included.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
1	Craig Goodwin	Adelaide United → Al-Wehda	Release clause	Figure reported	Al-Wehda "offered $450,000 to trigger the buyout clause" (Lewis, 2019b)
2*	Kearyn Baccus	Melbourne City → Kaizer Chiefs	Transfer fee	Inferred	Mid-contract exit; clubs "agreed terms" (Goal, 2019)
3*	Terry Antonis	Melbourne Victory → Suwon Bluewings	Transfer fee	Inferred	Mid-contract exit; Clubs "agreed to terms on the transfer" (Melbourne Victory, 2019)
4	Thomas Deng	Melbourne Victory → Urawa Red Diamonds	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 22 and inside the window; 3 qualifying years at Victory (Thomas Deng, n.d.)
5	Jacob Italiano	Perth Glory → Bor. Mönchengladbach	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Perth youth player whose move was agreed in December 2017 (Lewis, 2017), departure announced May 2019 (Perth Glory, 2019a); aged 17 at the move

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
6*	Jason Davidson	Perth Glory → Ulsan Hyundai	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Described as "sold off" to Ulsan (Yang, 2019)
7	Brandon O'Neill	Sydney FC → Pohang Steelers	Transfer fee	Band reported	Reported "close to agreeing a fee between $250,000 and $300,000" (Lewis, 2020); club confirms an undisclosed fee (Sydney FC, 2020a)
8	Ryan Teague	Sydney FC → Famalicão	Transfer fee	Band reported	Club accepted "a substantial six-figure transfer offer" (Sydney FC, 2020b)
9	Sarpreet Singh	Wellington Phoenix → Bayern Munich	Transfer fee	Band reported	Deal "worth between $750,000 and $1 million", plus add-ons (Burgess, 2019)
10	Connor Chapman	Western United → Daejeon Hana Citizen	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Daejeon's "first major transfer" of a new era (Neat, 2020)

** Inclusion flagged.* Baccus and Antonis: no source explicitly states that a fee was paid. Davidson: a fee is asserted only by an analysis outlet.

Entries requiring explanation

Four entries carry a published figure or range. The remaining six require more than the table can show.

Thomas Deng and Jacob Italiano rest on regulatory entitlement. Deng moved on 28 January 2020 aged 22 (The Japan Times, 2020). His 23rd birthday fell within the same season and his qualifying training years served at Victory entitled the club to a compensation payment (Thomas Deng, n.d.). Victory's statement was unclear whether a transfer fee was paid (Australian Associated Press, 2020), whilst the season records noted the move with an 'Undisclosed' label (2019–20 Melbourne Victory FC Season, n.d.). Ultimately, the move was recorded as compensation rather than a fee, because the entitlement is established, whilst the fee is not. Italiano was a Perth academy graduate whose move was held until his 18th birthday by FIFA's restrictions on the transfer of minors (FIFA, 2025; Perth Glory, 2019a), and Perth's own statement named no figure (Perth Glory, 2019a). Whether a negotiated fee was

also paid is unresolved, yet the entitlement from a Category I club for a player Perth trained from youth is owed either way.

Jason Davidson and Connor Chapman share a weakness. In both cases, contemporary coverage described the moves in terms that imply a fee was paid. Davidson was "sold off to K1 Giants Ulsan Hyundai" (Yang, 2019), while Chapman's move represented "the club's first major transfer of the Hana Finance Group era" (Neat, 2020). Yet neither selling club explicitly stated whether money was received, and no figure was published in either case. Both were mid-contract moves (FTBL, 2019; Perth Glory, 2019b), which is consistent with a fee having been paid. The inference is reasonable rather than established, and both carry that qualification. However, the two part in regards to their source. Chapman's inclusion rests on a news report of the buying club's dealings, whereas Davidson's appears only in an analysis piece, which is not authoritative enough to carry the entry. Davidson's departure is therefore flagged, and Chapman's is not.

Kearyn Baccus and Terry Antonis were both under contract, and both moves were announced as agreements between clubs, yet neither announcement used language that would indicate a fee was paid. Melbourne City's departure report notes Baccus left with roughly two years still left on his contract (Keep Up, n.d.a), whilst Kaizer Chiefs announced they had "agreed terms with the Australian A-League side Melbourne City" (Goal, 2019). Melbourne Victory's statement on Antonis is similar, recording only that the clubs had "agreed to terms on the transfer" (Melbourne Victory, 2019). Antonis had roughly a year left on his Victory contract at the time of his departure (Melbourne Victory, 2018). Terms agreed between clubs for a contracted player usually imply consideration, but in neither case did a club state that money was paid, and a negotiated release cannot be excluded on the reporting located. Both are retained because it is reasonable to assume a fee was paid, not because the money is evidenced, and both are flagged.

Departures that did not qualify

A potential qualification was the departure of Isaías, who was recorded as an Undisclosed entry in Adelaide's season record (2019–20 Adelaide United FC Season, n.d.). However, both the club and the league indicate that no transfer fee was paid. Adelaide announced that the captain "has decided to leave the Club to explore an opportunity overseas" (Adelaide United, 2019), and the A-Leagues' own ins-and-outs record for the cycle lists him as released (Keep Up, n.d.b). Further, at 32 he carried no compensation entitlement. Therefore, the move represents a case in the dataset where the source hierarchy supports not including this potential entry. Similarly, Roy Krishna's move to ATK was recorded as undisclosed (Transfermarkt, n.d.), yet it was a free transfer at the expiry of his Wellington contract, and at 31 he carried no entitlement (Windon, 2019).

Joe Caletti, a 20-year-old Brisbane academy product, was released at season's end and signed by Florø SK that August (Lewis, 2019a). A release at expiry does not void an entitlement, and

at 20 he was comfortably inside the age window, with roughly three qualifying years served at Brisbane (Lewis, 2019a). Florø, however, were a semi-professional club in the third tier of Norwegian football (2019 Norwegian Second Division, n.d.), which could not realistically be expected to sit above Category IV, leaving Brisbane with no compensation entitlement.

An observed limitation of this season's sample was that the competition census appeared to omit academy departures, whilst in later seasons, sales of academy players to European clubs surfaced through club announcements. Therefore, the sample likely omitted qualifying transfers through this limitation.

2020/21

The census for the cycle comprised 145 departures, of which ten were included. Macarthur FC joined the league as an expansion club this season.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
11	Lachlan Brook	Adelaide United → Brentford	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 19 with roughly four qualifying years at Adelaide; joined an English second-tier club (Brentford FC, n.d.)
12	Paul Izzo	Adelaide United → Xanthi	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club announces the transfer "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2020a)
13	Riley McGree	Adelaide United → Charlotte FC	Transfer fee	Figure reported	Club-stated transfer "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2020b); AUD 900,000 reported subsequently (Davutovic, 2022)
14	Brad Inman	Brisbane Roar → ATK Mohun Bagan	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club confirms an agreement "for an undisclosed fee" (Brisbane Roar, 2020)
15	Sam Silvera	Central Coast Mariners → Paços de Ferreira	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Reported as a move "for an undisclosed fee" at 19 (A-Leagues, 2020b)
16*	Gabriel Popović	Perth Glory → Xanthi	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 17, Perth youth from 2019, debut at 16 (Gabriel Popovic, n.d.)
17*	Kristian Popović	Perth Glory → Xanthi	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 19, Perth youth from 2018 (Kristian Popovic, n.d.)
18*	Callan Elliot	Wellington Phoenix → Xanthi	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 21, signed October 2018, roughly two qualifying years (Wellington Phoenix, 2020a)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
19*	Callum McCowatt	Wellington Phoenix → FC Helsingør	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 21, roughly ten months qualifying (Callum McCowatt, n.d.); joined a Danish second-tier club (New Zealand Football, 2020)
20	Liberato Cacace	Wellington Phoenix → Sint-Truiden	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Belgian reporting puts the fee above €1.2m (Het Laatste Nieuws, 2020); Wellington states only that terms were agreed (Wellington Phoenix, 2020b)

** Inclusion flagged.* Gabriel Popović, Kristian Popović, Elliot and McCowatt: the receiving club's category cannot be established, and Category IV cannot be ruled out. McCowatt also holds roughly ten months of qualifying service.

Entries requiring explanation

Cacace and McGree's departures represent the season's two largest reported figures. In both cases, a fee being paid was well established, yet the amount was not. Adelaide stated that McGree moved "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2020b), and the sum of AUD 900,000 comes from a later A-Leagues account of the club's return on him (Davutovic, 2022) rather than from any contemporary report. Cacace's case had greater ambiguity regarding the reported fee. The fee was asserted only in Belgian reporting, which reported it above €1.2 million (Het Laatste Nieuws, 2020), whilst Wellington stated only that it had "agreed terms with Sint-Truiden on the transfer" (Wellington Phoenix, 2020b). Contemporary New Zealand reporting disputed the Belgian figure, placing the fee in the mid-to-high six figures with add-ons (The Niche Cache, 2020). Both figures therefore carry this caveat, Cacace's especially.

Three of the five compensation entries share a common destination and weakness. Gabriel Popović, Kristian Popović and Callan Elliot all moved to Xanthi, a Super League Greece 2 side (Adelaide United, 2020a), between September and October 2020. All three satisfied the age and qualifying-service limbs, though with varying evidence. Wellington recorded that Elliot "departed the club following the conclusion of his contract", having signed in October 2018 and left aged 21 (Wellington Phoenix, 2020a). Neither Popović departure was followed by a club statement of any kind, and their ages, spans and contract status were only evidenced by the Perth Glory season record (2020–21 Perth Glory FC season, n.d.). Furthermore, Xanthi's category could not be established. Yet, what differentiates this case from Caletti's move to Florø SK is that Xanthi were a professional second-division club rather than a semi-

professional third-tier one, so Category III or above is the likelier reading. Category IV cannot be excluded, and all three are flagged accordingly.

Callum McCowatt's move to FC Helsingør satisfied the conditions to qualify for compensation, yet represents the only entry in the dataset flagged for two separate reasons. He joined Wellington on 26 June 2019 and turned 21 on 30 April 2020 (Callum McCowatt, n.d.), so of roughly fourteen months at the club only ten fall inside the qualifying period. Further, Helsingør had just won promotion to Denmark's second tier (New Zealand Football, 2020), leaving the same category question as Xanthi unresolved. McCowatt is therefore flagged because the qualifying period is twelve months or less, and because Category IV cannot be excluded.

Lachlan Brook's move to Brentford was classified as compensation rather than a fee, due to insufficient support that a fee was paid. Adelaide's season record labels the transfer as Undisclosed (2020–21 Adelaide United FC season, n.d.), yet Brentford's own announcement neither names a fee nor indicates that one was paid (Brentford FC, 2020). Brook had joined Adelaide's youth system in November 2016 and left in October 2020 aged 19 (Lachlan Brook, n.d.), giving the club roughly four qualifying years. As with other cases, in an effort not to over-claim on insufficient evidence, the entry qualifies based on the entitlement, which is established, rather than on the fee, which is not.

Departures that did not qualify

Alex Grant's move to Pohang Steelers was the season's most contested near miss. Perth's season record labels the departure Undisclosed (2020–21 Perth Glory FC season, n.d.), and an encyclopedia entry states that he "joined Pohang Steelers on an undisclosed fee transfer" with three seasons left on his contract (Alex Grant (soccer), n.d.). Both trace to a single report in The West Australian (11 December 2020) that could not be retrieved. Further sourced evidence, however, contradicts these reports. Perth's announcement in December 2020 included the heading "Grant departs to explore overseas opportunity" (Perth Glory, 2020), language clubs typically reserve for players leaving of their own accord, as seen in the wording that kept Isaías out of the previous season's sample (Adelaide United, 2019). Pohang did not announce the signing until February 2021, describing him as an Asia-quota addition and naming no fee (The AFC, 2021). Grant was therefore seemingly without a club for roughly two months, a pattern more consistent with a player leaving a club at the expiration or termination of his contract and signing with another at a later date, rather than transferring directly between the two. The contract claim is unsupported too. Perth's last recorded renewal for Grant was a two-year extension signed in April 2018 (Perth Glory, 2018), which would have expired in 2020. At 26 he carried no compensation entitlement, so the entry would rest on the fee alone. Because that fee is asserted only by sources which could not be checked, and is contradicted by those which could, the departure lacked the support to qualify for the sample.

Nick Fitzgerald's departure from Newcastle was recorded as Undisclosed in the club's season record (2020–21 Newcastle Jets FC season, n.d.), yet Newcastle's announcement states only that the club parted ways with him, without any indication of a fee being paid (Newcastle Jets, 2020). Further, at 28 the move carried no compensation entitlement. Therefore, without support beyond the season record, there was insufficient evidence for inclusion.

Jordan Murray and Bernie Ibini's departures this season address a nuanced idea of what qualifies for inclusion. Murray was recorded as Undisclosed in Central Coast's season record (2020–21 Central Coast Mariners FC season, n.d.), and the club confirmed that he "has been granted a release by the Club for an undisclosed fee to pursue an overseas opportunity" (Central Coast Mariners, 2020). The wording points towards a release the player purchased himself, rather than a fee paid by an acquiring club, though the statement does not say so outright. Ibini's case is more explicit, in that he was "granted an early release from his contract" (FTBL, 2020), which the Jets record as a contract buy-out by the player (2020–21 Newcastle Jets FC season, n.d.). In both cases money seemingly reached the club, which would satisfy the sample's criteria as written. However, neither serves what the sample is assembled to examine. A transfer fee earns its place in this dataset because it is a price a buying club chose to pay, and therefore a record that some club assessed an A-League player and judged him worth spending a specific transfer fee on. That judgement is the object of the analysis, which asks what attracts it and how clubs might sustainably reproduce that talent. A payment made to release a player does not carry that judgement. It prices the release rather than the player, and records what leaving was worth to him rather than what he was worth to anyone else. A buying club may well have funded it, in which case a valuation does sit behind the payment, but that valuation cannot be established from the available evidence. Admitting such cases would enlarge the sample whilst mixing two different quantities within it, so that the sample of departures returning money would no longer be a sample of players another club paid for. Finally, neither player carried a compensation entitlement to fall back on, at 25 and 28 respectively, so both departures are noted here rather than included.

2021/22

The census for the cycle comprised 155 departures, of which thirteen are included.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
21	Ben Halloran	Adelaide United → FC Seoul	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Transfer "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2022a)
22	Ryan Strain	Adelaide United → Maccabi Haifa	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Reds agree fee"; "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2021)
23	Stefan Mauk	Adelaide United → Fagiano Okayama	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Transfer "for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2022c)
24	Jordan Courtney-Perkins	Brisbane Roar → Raków Częstochowa	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 18, about three qualifying years (Jordan Courtney-Perkins, n.d.)
25	Alou Kuol	Central Coast → VfB Stuttgart	Transfer fee	Press-reported	A "six-figure sale" (Lewis, 2021) to a Category I club
26	Gianni Stensness	Central Coast → Viking FK	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 22 and inside the window; academy and senior service at the club (Gianni Stensness, n.d.)
27*	Denis Genreau	Macarthur FC → Toulouse	Transfer fee	Season-record only	Club notes only "a percentage of any further on sale" (Macarthur FC, 2021a); no fee stated in contemporary reporting
28	Matt Derbyshire	Macarthur FC → AEK Larnaca	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "agreed a transfer fee" for the move (Macarthur FC, 2021b)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
29	Nathaniel Atkinson	Melbourne City → Heart of Midlothian	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Hearts "agreed an undisclosed fee", with 18 months still to run (Anderson, 2021b)
30	Cameron Devlin	Newcastle Jets → Heart of Midlothian	Release clause	Band reported	A "buyout clause which amounts to five figures", triggered by Hearts (Anderson, 2021a)
31*	Tete Yengi	Newcastle Jets → Ipswich Town	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 20, about nine months qualifying (Tete Yengi, n.d.)
32	Aaron Calver	Perth Glory → Gwangju FC	Transfer fee	Press-reported	"Glory receiving an undisclosed fee for the 26-year-old" (Chadwick, 2022)
33	Joel King	Sydney FC → Odense BK	Release clause	Band reported	"A six figure transfer fee" on a clause triggered by Odense (Sydney FC, 2022a)

** Inclusion flagged*. Genreau: no club statement or contemporary report indicates a fee was paid, leaving the amount to compiled records. Yengi: holds roughly nine months of qualifying service.

Entries requiring explanation

Matt Derbyshire's departure is the clearest instance in the dataset of a club's account overturning a compiled label. The census records the move to AEK Larnaca as a free transfer, yet Macarthur stated that "the Bulls agreed a transfer fee for Matt Derbyshire to AEK LARNAKA of Cyprus" (Macarthur FC, 2021b). He had signed a two-year deal in August 2020 (Macarthur FC, 2020) and left eleven months into it, so the move was made mid-contract. No source names a sum, and at 35 he carried no compensation entitlement, so the entry rests on the club's statement alone, which the source hierarchy treats as sufficient.

Alou Kuol's departure shows a similar pattern. The Mariners announced that "VfB Stuttgart have agreed terms for the transfer of Alou Kuol", effective at the end of the season (Central Coast Mariners, 2021), and contemporary reporting described the move as a "six-figure sale" (Lewis, 2021). The season record lists it as a free transfer (2021–22 Central Coast Mariners FC season, n.d.). Kuol was 19 (Lewis, 2021) and a Mariners youth product (Central Coast Mariners, 2021), so a training-compensation entitlement from a German Category I club applied regardless of whether a fee was paid, which qualifies the entry on two separate

grounds. Lewis (2021) further reports that the deal was thought to include add-on clauses beyond the initial fee, which likely understates the club's eventual return.

Denis Genreau's departure represents an interesting case, resulting in its inclusion in the sample while also being flagged. Macarthur had signed him from Melbourne City on a free transfer in July 2020 on a three-year contract ("2020–21 Macarthur FC season," n.d.), and he left twelve months later with two years still to run, aged 22 ("Denis Genreau," n.d.). The census records €500,000 (Transfermarkt, n.d.) and the season record lists the move as undisclosed ("2021–22 Macarthur FC season," n.d.). However, the club's own statement, headed as a transfer, notes only that "the agreement includes a percentage of any further on sale" (Macarthur FC, 2021a). The wording seemingly implies a sale, since a percentage of a further sale presupposes a first one, yet it fails to explicitly state or directly indicate that a fee was paid. Further, both Australian and French coverage reported the move without reference to a fee (Curulli, 2021; Jucobin, 2021). The contrast with Derbyshire's departure is notable, as the same club used plain fee language through the same channel three weeks prior (Macarthur FC, 2021b). Because Genreau joined Macarthur two months after his twenty-first birthday, the club held no qualifying training service, so no entitlement is available to carry the entry. Ultimately, the entry is included on the basis that the balance of evidence indicates a sale likely occurred. However, because the evidence of payment rests on compiled records and an implication, the entry is flagged.

Gianni Stensness presents a case similar to those seen previously. The Mariners' season record labels the transfer Undisclosed (2021–22 Central Coast Mariners FC season, n.d.), and he departed with roughly a year still to run on a contract extended to 2022 (Gianni Stensness, n.d.). Viking's chief executive described the club as close to reaching "an agreement with both the player and the Australian club" (Bjerkevoll, 2021), yet no source states that a fee was paid. The entry is therefore classified on the entitlement, which is established. Stensness was 22 at the time of the move, with his 23rd birthday falling within the same season, so the departure sits inside the window on either reading. His qualifying service is split across two spells, an academy season in 2017 and a senior registration from August 2019 to his 21st birthday in February 2020, amounting to roughly eighteen months in total (Gianni Stensness, n.d.). Viking played in the Norwegian top flight (2021 Eliteserien, n.d.), well above the category at which no compensation is due. Both limbs are satisfied, and the Mariners were owed a payment whether or not a transfer fee was paid.

Tete Yengi joined Newcastle on a scholarship in December 2020, and left for Ipswich Town in September 2021 aged 20 (Tete Yengi, n.d.). The club therefore held roughly nine months of qualifying service. Ipswich were then in the English third tier (2021–22 EFL League One, n.d.), and the move was a free transfer (Claydon, 2021). The receiving club's category was not in doubt, but it sat low enough that, combined with the short qualifying period, the compensation owed to Newcastle would have been relatively small. The entry is therefore flagged on the qualifying period.

Departures that did not qualify

Joe Champness's departure was recorded as Undisclosed in Newcastle's season record (2021–22 Newcastle Jets FC season, n.d.), yet the club's own transfer centre states only that he "has been granted a release from his A-League contract" (Newcastle Jets, 2021), naming no fee. The release was announced in June 2021 and he did not join Giresunspor until August, so he moved as a free agent. At 24 he was past the compensation window, and without support beyond the season record there was insufficient evidence for inclusion.

2022/23

The census for the cycle comprised 182 departures, of which seventeen are included.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
34	Mohamed Touré	Adelaide United → Stade Reims	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Reds agree transfer fee… for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2022b)
35	Yaya Dukuly	Adelaide United → Stade Reims	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Named in the same club announcement as Touré (Adelaide United, 2022b)
36*	Cyrus Dehmie	Brisbane Roar → Næstved BK	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 20, Roar academy, about four qualifying years ("Cyrus Dehmie," n.d.)
37*	Jesse Daley	Brisbane Roar → Cavalry FC	Transfer fee	Inferred	Club "wishes to advise of the transfer"; mid-season, unpriced (Brisbane Roar, 2022)
38	Garang Kuol	Central Coast → Newcastle United	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "agreed terms for the sale" (Central Coast Mariners, 2022a)
39*	Kelechi John	Central Coast → Belenenses SAD	Transfer fee	Inferred	Club "can confirm the transfer"; mid-season, unpriced (Central Coast Mariners, 2023)
40	Kye Rowles	Central Coast → Heart of Midlothian	Transfer fee	Press-reported	An undisclosed fee reported on a three-year deal (Sked, 2022)
41	Mark Birighitti	Central Coast → Dundee United	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "agreed to sell… for an undisclosed fee" (Central Coast Mariners, 2022b)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
42	Lewis Miller	Macarthur FC → Hibernian	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"A satisfactory figure with an additional on sell percentage" (Macarthur FC, 2022)
43	Connor Metcalfe	Melbourne City → FC St. Pauli	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"An undisclosed fee has been reached between the two clubs" (Melbourne City, 2022)
44	Brendan Hamill	Melbourne Victory → ATK Mohun Bagan	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Departs "for an undisclosed transfer fee" (Melbourne Victory, 2022)
45	Nick D'Agostino	Melbourne Victory → Viking FK	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "transferred… for an undisclosed fee" (Melbourne Victory, 2023)
46	Joshua Rawlins	Perth Glory → FC Utrecht	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Glory will receive an undisclosed fee for Rawlins" (Perth Glory, 2022b)
47	Elvis Kamsoba	Sydney FC → Sepahan	Transfer fee	Band reported	Club records an "undisclosed six-figure transfer fee" (Sydney FC, 2022b)
48	Patrick Yazbek	Sydney FC → Viking FK	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Fee "breaks a club record for a graduate from the Sky Blues Academy" (Sydney FC, 2023)
49	Ben Waine	Wellington Phoenix → Plymouth Argyle	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Dome: "the fee reflected our valuation of the player" (Robinson, 2023)
50*	Phillip Cancar	Western Sydney → Livingston	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 21; at the Wanderers from 19, about twelve qualifying months ("Phillip Cancar," n.d.)

** Inclusion flagged*. Daley and Kelechi John: no club statement or report indicates a fee was paid. Dehmie: the receiving club's category cannot be established, and Category IV cannot be ruled out. Cancar: the Wanderers held roughly twelve months of qualifying service.

Entries requiring explanation

A notable pattern across the included departures is the systematic understatement of A-League transfer income by the census. Dukuly, Miller, Metcalfe and Rawlins were each recorded as free transfers (Transfermarkt, n.d.), despite the selling club in each case stating that a fee was involved (Adelaide United, 2022b; Macarthur FC, 2022; Melbourne City, 2022; Perth Glory, 2022). Four of the season's eighteen inclusions therefore carry no indication of payment in the census, reinforcing the point that significant weight placed on such records would understate both the number and the value of qualifying departures. The census is accordingly useful for establishing who left, rather than as evidence of what was paid.

Jesse Daley (25) and Kelechi John (24) are the season's only inferred entries. Neither club named a figure, yet both described the departure as a "transfer" (Brisbane Roar, 2022; Central Coast Mariners, 2023; "Kelechi John," n.d.). The term typically implies a registered player moving between clubs by agreement, usually in exchange for a fee. Across the dataset, Brisbane Roar were notably consistent in their announcement language, appearing to reserve distinct terminology for different types of departure (Brisbane Roar, 2023, 2025). Their use of the label "transfer" therefore lends greater weight to the inference drawn. Both departures also occurred mid-season, and a contracted player does not ordinarily move mid-season without the clubs agreeing terms. Therefore, both were included on the basis that the evidence suggested a fee was paid in each case. However, neither is supported by an explicit statement of payment, so both were flagged.

Cyrus Dehmie's departure carries the same announcement wording as Daley's, with Brisbane Roar advising of "the transfer of striker Cyrus Dehmie to Danish 1st Division club Næstved Boldklub" (Brisbane Roar, 2023), and again no figure was given. However, the same inference was not required here. He was 20 and had roughly four qualifying years behind him ("Cyrus Dehmie," n.d.), so the entry is classified on the entitlement, which is established, rather than on an inferred fee. Næstved, despite the name of their division, played in the second tier of Danish football ("2022–23 Danish 1st Division," n.d.). They most likely sat above the threshold to entitle Brisbane to compensation, yet Category IV cannot be ruled out, and the entry was therefore flagged.

Phillip Cancar's move satisfied the requirements for compensation entitlement. He departed at 21 on a free transfer to a Scottish top-flight club, comfortably above the category at which compensation ceases to be payable ("Phillip Cancar," n.d.; "2022–23 Scottish Premiership," n.d.). Yet the entry is flagged because he joined Western Sydney at 19, leaving the Wanderers with roughly twelve months of qualifying service before his 21st birthday.

Departures that did not qualify

The season record lists Liam Rose's departure from Macarthur as undisclosed ("2022–23 Macarthur FC season," n.d.). He joined El Paso Locomotive in the USL Championship, whose announcement of the signing makes no reference to terms (USL Championship, 2022), and no statement from Macarthur was found. Given the unreliability of season-record labels, there was insufficient evidence to include the departure. Rose was also 25 at the time ("Liam Rose," n.d.), so no compensation entitlement arose.

There were also several departures by players inside the compensation window that did not qualify for inclusion. Jack McLoughlin joined Hampton & Richmond Borough in the English sixth tier ("Hampton & Richmond Borough F.C.," n.d.), Luis Toomey joined Pallo-Iirot in the Finnish fourth tier, Lachlan Sepping joined APEA Akrotiri in the Cypriot lower divisions ("APEA Akrotiri," n.d.), and Jacob Maniti joined the Azkals Development Team in the Philippines Football League. None of these clubs could reasonably be placed above Category IV, so no compensation was payable. Conversely, Pacifique Niyongabire's move to Valour FC failed for a different reason. He joined Perth Glory in July 2021, four months after his 21st birthday, so the club held no qualifying training years and nothing was owed (Perth Glory, 2022; "Pacifique Niyongabire," n.d.).

2023/24

The census for the cycle comprised 151 departures, of which twenty-seven were included, the largest season in the dataset.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
51	Alexandar Popović	Adelaide United → Gwangju FC	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "announced the sale of Popović" (Alexandar Popovic, n.d.)
52	Craig Goodwin	Adelaide United → Al-Wehda	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€742,000 (indicative)
53	Giuseppe Bovalina	Adelaide United → Vancouver Whitecaps	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€135,000 (indicative)
54	Joe Gauci	Adelaide United → Aston Villa	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,500,000 (indicative); club calls it "a good amount" (Keep Up, 2024c)
55*	Louis D'Arrigo	Adelaide United → Lechia Gdańsk	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 21, Adelaide academy graduate
56	Steven Hall	Adelaide United → Brighton & Hove Albion	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Has joined… for a transfer fee"; aged 19 (Adelaide United, 2023b)
57	Anthony Pavlešić	Central Coast → Bayern Munich	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"The sale… for an undisclosed fee"; aged 17 (Central Coast Mariners, 2023a)
58	James McGarry	Central Coast → Aberdeen	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "agree transfer"; six-figure fee reported (Central Coast Mariners, 2023b)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
59	Jason Cummings	Central Coast → Mohun Bagan	Transfer fee	Press-reported	"Joins Mohun Bagan for undisclosed fee" (Socceroos, 2023)
60	Marco Túlio	Central Coast → Kyoto Sanga	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"An undisclosed fee was agreed" (Central Coast Mariners, 2024)
61	Nectarios Triantis	Central Coast → Sunderland	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€350,000; season record gives £300,000
62	Sam Silvera	Central Coast → Middlesbrough	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€585,000 (indicative)
63*	Jonathan Aspropotamitis	Macarthur FC → Pohang Steelers	Transfer fee	Inferred	Club "reached an agreement… for the transfer"; mid-season (Keep Up, 2023a)
64	Aziz Behich	Melbourne City → Al-Nassr	Loan fee	Figure reported	€1,210,000, matching AUD 2,000,000 in the season record
65	Jordan Bos	Melbourne City → KVC Westerlo	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,300,000; season record gives AUD 2,000,000
66	Marco Tilio	Melbourne City → Celtic	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,750,000 (indicative); club calls it "record-breaking" (Melbourne City, 2023b)
67	Sebastian Esposito	Melbourne City → Lecce	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 18, City academy graduate, to a Category I club
68	Franco Lino	Melbourne Victory → Viking FK	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€130,000 (indicative)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
69	Jaushua Sotirio	Newcastle Jets → Kerala Blasters	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Buying club: "for an undisclosed fee" (Indian Super League, 2023)
70	Chris Donnell	Perth Glory → Fulham	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Signed by… for an undisclosed fee"; aged 19 (Perth Glory, 2023)
71*	Joseph Forde	Perth Glory → Waterford FC	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 20, about four qualifying years at Perth
72	Keegan Jelacic	Perth Glory → KAA Gent	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€180,000 (indicative)
73	Diego Caballo	Sydney FC → Aalborg BK	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Announcement headed "sold to Danish club" (Sydney FC, 2023)
74	Paulo Retre	Sydney FC → FC Goa	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Buying club "agreed an undisclosed transfer fee with Sydney FC" (FC Goa, 2023)
75	Calem Nieuwenhof	Western Sydney → Heart of Midlothian	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"For an undisclosed transfer fee" (Western Sydney Wanderers, 2023b)
76	Kusini Yengi	Western Sydney → Portsmouth	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"For an undisclosed transfer fee" (Western Sydney Wanderers, 2023a)
77*	Connor Pain	Western United → Al-Orobah	Transfer fee	Inferred	Club "agreed to the transfer", six months after a three-year extension (Western United, 2023a, 2023b)

** Inclusion flagged*. Aspropotamitis and Pain: the selling club described an agreement to transfer without indicating that a fee was paid. D'Arrigo and Forde: the receiving club could

reasonably be Category IV, Lechia as a second-tier club and Waterford in an association that publishes no categories.

Entries requiring explanation

Three A-League academy players transferred to major European clubs in this season's dataset, namely, Anthony Pavlešić to Bayern Munich, Chris Donnell to Fulham, and Sebastian Esposito to Lecce. None appeared in any competition-level departure list, because all three were academy rather than first-team registrations. Yet, they surfaced due to club announcements and season records. This was seemingly due to the introduction of such academy moves being added to such reporting, which seemed to have been missing in previous seasons. Therefore, addressing arguably the most present flaw in the previous seasons' dataset, resulting in the true dataset not being reflected in the sample.

Aziz Behich's departure represents the only loan fee in the dataset. Melbourne City's announcement mentioned no loan fee (Melbourne City, 2024), yet the inclusion does not rest on press reporting. Football Australia's transfer report for 2023/24 lists the move among the five largest international transfers of the season, in a table ranked by total transfer fee, and places it above Craig Goodwin's permanent sale to Al Wehdah (Football Australia, 2024). That table covers fees received by Australian clubs, which totalled AUD 17,452,389 across the season, so a move returning nothing could not appear on it. Additionally, Behich himself discussed the negotiations in a manner that insinuated that Melbourne City negotiated a deal beyond wage considerations (Keep Up, 2024a). The report gives no figure for any individual deal, so the amount remains unresolved, and the EUR 1,210,000 carried in the competition record has no traceable source.

Connor Pain and Jonathan Aspropotamitis were both included based on the same inference that qualified Jesse Daley and Kelechi John in the previous season's sample. Both were contracted players whose club announced they transferred to foreign clubs mid-season, without explicitly stating whether a fee had been paid. Therefore, they should carry the same qualifications as Daley and John's moves.

Two entries based on compensation, Louis D'Arrigo and Joseph Forde, can neither be specifically sized regarding what category the buying club fell into. Louis D'Arrigo, a 21-year-old Adelaide academy graduate, joined Lechia Gdańsk, with Adelaide's announcement including no fee language (Adelaide United, 2023a). While Joseph Forde, 20, left Perth by mutual termination for Waterford, with about three qualifying years behind him (Perth Glory, 2024). The difficulty with D'Arrigo and Forde is that neither the Polish nor the Irish association publishes its club category assignments. Lechia played in I liga, the Polish second tier, and Waterford had spent the previous two seasons in the First Division before being promoted seven weeks ahead of Forde's signing. Neither sits where the rule allows Category IV to be ruled out, so both entries are flagged. In each case the entitlement rests on an inference, and its size cannot be calculated from public sources.

Departures that did not qualify

Three under-23 candidates just failed to qualify based on their age calculations. Specifically, Al Hassan Touré, Luke Ivanovic, and Nick Suman departed to foreign clubs just months after turning 23. Therefore, all three had just passed the end of the entitlement window, prior to their transfers.

One case that is genuinely unresolved was Rahmat Akbari's departure to Torpedo Kutaisi eight days after turning 23. What differentiates this move from the three noted above is that it falls inside the window on FIFA's calendar-year formulation, but outside of the season formulation. It is unclear whether this qualifies for compensation or not, therefore, it was excluded from the sample, due to insufficient evidence to support inclusion.

2024/25

The census for the cycle comprised 174 departures, of which twenty-three are included. Eleven are supported by a figure, the most of any season. Auckland FC joined the league as an expansion club this season.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
78	Musa Touré	Adelaide United → Clermont Foot 63	Transfer fee	Press-reported	"Joins Clermont Foot for undisclosed fee"; aged 18 (Keep Up, 2024b)
79	Nestory Irankunda	Adelaide United → Bayern Munich	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€900,000 (indicative); club records an undisclosed fee
80	Rylan Brownlie	Brisbane Roar → Crystal Palace	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 18; Category I destination (Crystal Palace, 2025)
81*	Shae Cahill	Brisbane Roar → Nottingham Forest	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 19, about nine months qualifying (Nottingham Forest, 2024)
82	Thomas Waddingham	Brisbane Roar → Portsmouth	Transfer fee	Figure reported	£200,000 reported; club "agree transfer"
83	Jacob Farrell	Central Coast → Portsmouth	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club agreed the transfer "for an undisclosed fee" (Central Coast Mariners, 2024)
84	Ariath Piol	Macarthur FC → Real Salt Lake	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€450,000; season record gives AUD 830,000

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
85	Jed Drew	Macarthur FC → TSV Hartberg	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Macarthur "sell Jed Drew to European club" (Keep Up, 2025)
86	Oliver Jones	Macarthur FC → Randers FC	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€240,000; season record gives AUD 400,000
87	Raphael Borges Rodrigues	Macarthur FC → Coventry City	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Buying side: "for an undisclosed fee"; aged 20 (Coventry Telegraph, 2025)
88	Connor Chapman	Melbourne Victory → Gimpo FC	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Departs "for an undisclosed compensation" (Melbourne Victory, 2024a)
89	Paul Izzo	Melbourne Victory → Randers FC	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Victory net a "considerable" transfer fee (Keep Up, 2024a)
90	Apostolos Stamatelopoulos	Newcastle Jets → Motherwell	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€308,000; season record gives AUD 501,000
91	Daniel Bennie	Perth Glory → Queens Park Rangers	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€297,000 (indicative)
92	Hayden Matthews	Sydney FC → Portsmouth	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,500,000; season record gives AUD 2,500,000
93	Jake Girdwood-Reich	Sydney FC → St. Louis CITY SC	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€795,000 (indicative)
94	Alex Paulsen	Wellington Phoenix → AFC Bournemouth	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€2,270,000 (indicative)

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
95	Ben Old	Wellington Phoenix → AS Saint-Étienne	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Phoenix "accepted an undisclosed transfer fee" (Wellington Phoenix, 2024)
96	Finn Surman	Wellington Phoenix → Portland Timbers	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€500,000 (indicative)
97*	Oskar van Hattum	Wellington Phoenix → Sligo Rovers	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 22; about six qualifying years in the academy
98	Lachlan Brook	Western Sydney → Real Salt Lake	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€450,000 (indicative)
99*	Tom Heward-Belle	Western United → Montedio Yamagata	Transfer fee	Inferred	Club "reached an agreement for the transfer"; mid-season (Western United, 2024)

** Inclusion flagged*. Cahill: Brisbane held roughly ten months of qualifying service. Van Hattum: the receiving club's category cannot be established, and Category IV cannot be ruled out. Heward-Belle: the selling club described an agreement to transfer a contracted player without indicating that a fee was paid.

Entries requiring explanation

The figures in this cycle are better corroborated than elsewhere in the dataset. Yet, it should be noted that the clubs confirm that a fee was paid, yet the amounts are third-party estimates. Therefore, the transfer fees are useful for gauging the scale of a deal, rather than an exact record of what was paid.

Nestory Irankunda's move exemplifies what the dataset can and cannot measure. Adelaide recorded the move with an Undisclosed label, whilst the €900,000 fee is database-derived. Unlike almost every other move considered, likely due to the deal's marquee nature, Transfermarkt included a note indicating the highly-varied initially reported fee range, €750,000- €3.4 million (Transfermarkt, n.d.). Further, Adelaide United announced that the sale of Irankunda was a new record transfer, surpassing a previous record of €1.5 million (Adelaide United, 2023c; Transfermarkt, n.d.). Where the variability in reported fees likely stem from, is the deal's inclusion of additional considerations, beyond the initial fee. The

€900,000 figure likely represents an estimate of the initial transfer only. Therefore, not accounting for guaranteed future payments, performance-based add-ons, a sell-on clause, and further considerations beyond just an initial fee. Resulting in Adelaide likely recouping a fee significantly greater than the €900,000 figure. Yet, these details are even more challenging to source and estimate accurately then even the initial fee. Therefore, further differentiating the estimates from an exact record of what was paid in numerous cases, such as Lewis Miller in 2022-23.

Wellington Phoenix accounted for four of the twenty-three departures. Paulsen to Bournemouth, Old to Saint-Étienne and Surman to Portland all returned transfer fees. While van Hattum's move accounted for roughly six qualifying academy-years of compensation with his departure to Sligo Rovers. No other club in any season contributes four money-returning departures at once.

Further, two entries were presented incorrectly by the databases labels once again. Namely, Ben Old and Connor Chapman's move were both labelled as free transfers, despite their club announcements stating that an undisclosed transfer fee/compensation were recouped (Wellington Phoenix, 2024; Melbourne Victory, 2024a).

Another reoccurring issue was the databases were their omission of Rylan Brownlie and Shae Cahill's moves from their departure list. Both players left Brisbane for Category I English clubs (Crystal Palace and Nottingham Forest), and qualified for compensation for Brisbane.

Van Hattum's entitlement cannot be sized, because the Football Association of Ireland publishes no club category assignments. Sligo Rovers sit in a small association where Category IV cannot be excluded, so the entry is flagged rather than treated as a settled entitlement. The same reasoning flags Joseph Forde's move to Waterford in the previous season.

Tom Heward-Belle represents the season's only inferred entry. Western United neither named a figure, nor explicitly stated a fee was paid. However, the announcement did note that a transfer had occurred for an under-contract player mid-season. Thus, the move qualifies for the sample on the same basis as Pain, Aspropotamitis, Daley and John, yet should include the same cavate.

Departures that did not qualify

Jason Geria's move's only supporting evidence for inclusion is Victory's season record listing the move as Undisclosed. Therefore, it was excluded from the sample, due to sources' tendency to mislabel departures.

Further, Doni Grdić, Cristian Caicedo, and Néicer Acosta's moves were excluded from the sample for a shared reason. Despite the three under-23 players departing for an overseas destination, they all joined their selling club aged 21. Therefore, not accounting for any training compensation in return, calculated only on training years between 12 and 21 (FIFA, n.d.).

Conversely, Max Balard move to NAC Breda was not a close consideration for inclusion in the sample, rather just an increasing case. Max had just aged out of entitling the Mariners to registry compensation, yet was under-contract prior to his free transfer to the Dutch club. The free transfer occurred because his contract extension that month carried an explicit clause permitting a free move abroad.

2025/26

The census for the cycle comprised 142 departures, of which fifteen are included. Western United fielded no team this season.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
100	Archie Goodwin	Adelaide United → Charlotte FC	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€769,000 (indicative); "for an undisclosed fee"; aged 20 (Keep Up, 2025a)
101	Lucas Herrington	Brisbane Roar → Colorado Rapids	Transfer fee	Figure reported	Club states the transfer has returned more than AUD 1.5m (Brisbane Roar, 2026)
102	Kealey Adamson	Macarthur FC → Queens Park Rangers	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€300,000 (indicative); season record Undisclosed
103	Kai Trewin	Melbourne City → New York City FC	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€830,000 (indicative); club: "for an undisclosed fee" (Melbourne City, 2026)
104	Kasey Bos	Melbourne Victory → 1. FSV Mainz 05	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€500,000 (indicative); "for an undisclosed transfer fee"; aged 21 (Melbourne Victory, 2025a)
105	Ryan Teague	Melbourne Victory → KV Mechelen	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club confirms departure "for an undisclosed fee" (Melbourne Victory, 2025b)
106	Jaylan Pearman	Perth Glory → Queens Park Rangers	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 19, documented academy product; Category II destination
107	Rhys Bozinovski	Perth Glory → Heracles Almelo	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€260,000 (indicative); season record Undisclosed; aged 21

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
108	Adrian Segečić	Sydney FC → Portsmouth	Training compensation	Band reported	Club: "a substantial six-figure fee in training compensation" (Sydney FC, 2025)
109*	Dublin Boon	Wellington Phoenix → Stellenbosch	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 20; about 12 qualifying months
110	Alex Bonetig	Western Sydney → Portland Timbers	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,700,000 (indicative); club: "a club record transfer fee" (Western Sydney Wanderers, 2026)
111	Marcus Younis	Western Sydney → Brøndby IF	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€300,000 (indicative); season record Undisclosed; aged 20
112	Nicolas Milanovic	Western Sydney → Aberdeen	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€475,000 (indicative); season record Undisclosed
113	Oscar Priestman	Western Sydney → Motherwell	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Reported as the Wanderers selling the player (Keep Up, 2025b)
114	Zac Sapsford	Western Sydney → Dundee United	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club "agreed to an undisclosed transfer fee" (Western Sydney Wanderers, 2025)

* *Inclusion flagged*. Boon: Wellington held roughly twelve months of qualifying service.

Entries requiring explanation

Dublin Boon's departure to Stellenbosch is the season's only compensation entry. He left Wellington at the expiry of his first professional contract aged 20, which places the move inside the compensation window, and Stellenbosch play in the South African top flight, so a CAF Category II rate applies. Wellington held roughly twelve qualifying months, which is the least the regulation recognises as a training year, so the entry is flagged. The competition record lists the move as a free transfer.

An interesting case this season was with regards to the transfer of Lucas Herrington, and the club's unusually open nature regarding the financial recoupment they received from the departure. A club media release in June 2026, following Colorado Rapids' buyout of Brisbane's sell-on percentage, states that Herrington "has now returned more than AUD$1.5 million" to the club (Brisbane Roar, 2026). Despite the reported figure not reflecting an exact amount, it has been unusual for a club's media to directly report a fee at all themselves. Furthermore, due to the reliable nature of the figure's sourcing, the departure displays a great example of how financial beneficial a sell-on clause can be, especially for a developing talent.

Departures that did not qualify

Five departures failed to recoup a compensation fee due to the acquisition club's category band, namely: Will Wilson (Vaasan Palloseura), Matthew Scarcella (IL Hødd), Jake Hollman (Walsall), Gordon Iro (Solomon Kings) and Alen Harbas (Chalkanoras Dali). All left at expiry to clubs at or near the lowest band, where no training compensation is payable (FIFA, n.d.).

2026/27 (mid-year window)

The 2026/27 mid-year window comprised 166 departures, of which thirteen are included.

Departures that returned money

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
115	Luka Jovanović	Adelaide United → San Jose Earthquakes	Transfer fee	Figure reported	Club states "a seven-figure fee"; census records €600,000 (Adelaide United, 2026a)
116	Stefan Mauk	Adelaide United → Cong An Ha Noi	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Buying club took up "the option to buy… included in the agreement" (Adelaide United, 2026b)
117	Yaya Dukuly	Adelaide United → NK Celje	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club states the move was "completed for an undisclosed fee" (Adelaide United, 2026c)
118	Louis Verstraete	Auckland FC → Patro Eisden	Transfer Fee	Press-reported	League outlet reports the club "receiving an undisclosed transfer fee" (Dodd, 2026); the club says the same (Auckland FC, 2026)
119	Sam Klein	Brisbane Roar → FC St. Pauli	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Move includes "a significant transfer fee and a sell-on agreement" (Brisbane Roar, 2026b)
120	Patrick Beach	Melbourne City → Troyes	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,700,000 (indicative); club states "a permanent transfer… for an undisclosed fee" (Melbourne City, 2026)
121*	Joshua Rawlins	Melbourne Victory → Dundee United	Training compensation	Regulatory entitlement	Aged 22; about ten qualifying months at Victory

#	Player	Move	Deal type	Evidence	Support
122	Nishan Velupillay	Melbourne Victory → FC Ingolstadt 04	Transfer fee	Club-stated	"Completed a transfer… for an undisclosed fee"; academy graduate (Melbourne Victory, 2026a)
123	Clayton Taylor	Newcastle Jets → Barnsley	Transfer fee	Band reported	Buying club "paid a substantial six-figure fee for the 22-year-old" (Oxley, 2026)
124	Eli Adams	Newcastle Jets → Gamba Osaka	Transfer fee	Press-reported	Reported as an undisclosed fee; buying club confirms a permanent transfer (Gamba Osaka, 2026)
125	Khoa Ngo	Perth Glory → Cong An Ho Chi Minh City	Transfer fee	Club-stated	Club confirms a permanent move following an earlier loan; aged 20 (Perth Glory, 2026)
126	Paul Okon-Engstler	Sydney FC → 1. FC Köln	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€1,750,000 (indicative); move "netting the Sky Blues a seven-figure fee" (Keep Up, 2026b)
127	Luke Brooke-Smith	Wellington Phoenix → Portsmouth	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€465,000, matching the £400,000 reported by the buying side (Wellington Phoenix, 2026a)
128	Tim Payne	Wellington Phoenix → Club Olimpia	Transfer fee	Figure reported	€350,000; club states it accepted "an undisclosed fee" (Wellington Phoenix, 2026b)

* *Inclusion flagged*. Rawlins: Melbourne Victory held roughly ten months of qualifying service.

Entries requiring explanation

Two departures were publicly described as a "seven-figure fee": Paul Okon-Engstler, reported in the competition's own coverage (Keep Up, 2026b), and Luka Jovanović, stated by the selling club itself (Adelaide United, 2026a). The significance lies in the disclosure, rather than the

sum, since comparable sales in past seasons were never quantified publicly. Exemplifying a broader trend whereby clubs, and selling clubs in particular, have grown progressively more forthcoming about player trading.

Further exemplified with Sam Klein's move to FC St. Pauli, whereby Brisbane Roar confirmed the inclusion of a “a sell-on agreement" (Brisbane Roar, 2026b). Noting a second consecutive season where the club publicly announced their retention of a sell-on clause.

Two loan arrangements from 2025-26 converted into purchases this season. Stefan Mauk and Khoa Ngo both joined Vietnamese clubs on loan in the previous window. Adelaide stated that Cong An Ha Noi took up “the option to buy that was included in the agreement” (Adelaide United, 2026b), whereas Perth recorded only that Ngo “has completed a permanent move” after initially joining on loan, with no option mentioned by any source (Perth Glory, 2026). Neither announcement names a fee.

Joshua Rawlins permanently signed for Melbourne Victory in June 2024 aged 20, and left at the expiry of that deal in June 2026, which leaves about ten months of qualifying time before his 21st birthday. Victory headlined the departure an “overseas transfer” and named Dundee United, but stated no fee (Melbourne Victory, 2026b). Whilst the census records an undisclosed fee, which on the standard set, cannot establish one. Therefore, the departure is admitted on the entitlement, similarly to McCowatt, Yengi and Boon, of previous seasons.

Two entries, Clayton Taylor and Yaya Dukuly, are recorded in the census as free transfers. Adelaide stated that Dukuly’s move to NK Celje was “completed for an undisclosed fee” (Adelaide United, 2026c). Taylor is the clearer case of the two, once the mechanism is understood. He ran his Newcastle contract down to its expiry (Newcastle Jets, 2026), so no transfer fee could arise, yet Barnsley arrived “paying out a compensation fee to A-League outfit Newcastle Jets” (Wobschall, 2026), distinguished in the same passage from the fees that club paid for two other signings. The entry is therefore recorded as training compensation rather than a transfer fee. A free transfer label is the usual coding for an out-of-contract move that still carries compensation, which is the error this dataset exists to catch. Both are further instances of the error observed across the dataset, and the reason no entry is classified on a compiled label alone.

Departures that did not qualify

Two moves to European clubs produced nothing because the selling club held no qualifying years. Jesse Randall and Nathanael Blair’s moves abroad both qualify for compensation on the basis of their age at the time of the transfer. However, both joined Auckland FC and Central Coast after their 21st birthday, thus, voiding the selling club’s qualification for compensation. The same basis that excluded Grdić, Caicedo, Acosta and Prso previously.

Aidan Simmons’ departure represents the second observed case in the dataset, that is excluded on the basis of the season-versus-calendar-year ambiguity, which excluded Rahmat

Akbari in 2023-24. Western Sydney retained to close two qualifying years prior to his 21st birthday, and he left for Tochigi City at the expiry of his contract. He turned 23 at the very end of the 2025-26 season, and his departure was recorded at the end of June. This falls inside the window on FIFA's calendar-year formulation, but outside of the season formulation. Following the treatment set out in the Regulatory Tests, the departure is excluded.

In contrast, Mark Natta satisfied neither reading. His 23rd birthday occurred in November 2025, so when his contract expired and he moved on a free transfer to Cesena in July 2026, he was past both the end of that calendar year and the end of that season. Therefore, Newcastle was owed no compensation, despite roughly seventeen months of qualifying time before his 21st birthday. No source describes the move as a free transfer. Newcastle listed him among players departing at the expiry of their contract (Newcastle Jets, 2026) and Cesena announced the signing without naming a fee (Cesena FC, 2026).

Finally, Finn McKenlay's move to Finn Harps and Luke Supyk's move to Gateshead were both excluded on the category limb of the clubs they joined after the expiry of their contracts. Finn Harps play in the second tier in the Republic of Ireland, a small association, whereas Gateshead are in the fifth tier in England. Both are almost certainly Category IV, which attracts no compensation, regardless of the player's age or the training years held. Yet, neither association publishes its categorisation, so both exclusions rest on inference rather than a citable source (FIFA, n.d.).

References

Part A cites the regulatory and competition-structure sources listed below. Part B cites the evidence for each individual entry, and those citations are hyperlinked in place rather than listed here, so that each one leads straight to the club statement or report it rests on.

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